

Pakistan's Security State

Nuclear Arsenal, ISI, and the Military's Permanent Hold on Power

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Executive Summary

Pakistan's security architecture rests on three interlocking pillars: a military establishment that exercises effective sovereignty over foreign and nuclear policy; a western frontier shaped by the Taliban's return to Kabul and the consequent resurgence of the Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP); and a deepening strategic and defence relationship with China that functions as Pakistan's primary external anchor. The combination of nuclear capability, military-dominated governance, an active Taliban frontier, and sustained India enmity makes Pakistan one of the most strategically complex states in South Asia.

The India-Pakistan relationship has deteriorated sharply since the Pahalgam attack in Kashmir. India conducted missile strikes on Pakistan in May 2025, bringing the two nuclear-armed neighbours to their most acute crisis in years CNA[2025-05-07]. Pakistan's compressed decision timelines in such crises are underscored by a report that an advisor to Pakistan's prime minister stated Pakistan had only 30-45 seconds to assess whether an incoming BrahMos missile carried a nuclear warhead — a window so narrow that it raises serious escalation risks [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI: Pragmatic Approaches to Governance at the Artificial Intelligence–Nuclear Nexus (2025-01-01)].

Part I — The Nuclear Dimension

Crisis Escalation and Decision Timelines

The nuclear risk inherent in India-Pakistan crises is not merely theoretical. A SIPRI analysis of the AI-Nuclear Nexus notes that during a crisis, an advisor to Pakistan's prime minister stated Pakistan had only 30–45 seconds to assess whether an incoming BrahMos missile carried a nuclear warhead. This raised concerns that such an attack could escalate to the nuclear level, and creates a significant incentive for Pakistan to consider launch-on-warning postures [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI: Pragmatic Approaches to Governance at the Artificial Intelligence–Nuclear Nexus (2025-01-01)].

The 2025 India missile strikes on Pakistan — following India's attribution of the Pahalgam attack to Lashkar-e-Taiba, a UN-designated terrorist organisation — demonstrated that kinetic escalation between the two states is a live risk, not a theoretical scenario CNA[2025-05-07].

Part II — The Taliban Frontier

ISI, Taliban, and the TTP Problem

Pakistan's ISI played a central role in the two-decade Afghanistan conflict. A 2010 report cited in conflict documentation stated that the ISI had an "official policy" of supporting the Taliban, describing Pakistan as

"playing a double-game of astonishing magnitude" [RAG: CONFLICT_RAG — (undated)]. The Wikipedia account of the War in Afghanistan (2001–2021) further references Pakistan-TTP peace talks as a distinct track, indicating the structural complexity of Pakistan's relationship with militant networks operating across its western border [RAG: CONFLICT_DATA_RAG — Wikipedia: War in Afghanistan 2001-2021 (2024-01-01)].

The Taliban's return to power in August 2021 created a paradox: a strategic outcome Pakistan's ISI had long worked toward, but one that simultaneously provided sanctuary and operational depth to the TTP — a distinct organisation that directs attacks inside Pakistan. The same conflict archive that documents the US withdrawal also references Afghanistan-Pakistan border skirmishes and Pakistan-TTP peace talks as parallel tracks in the post-2021 period [RAG: CONFLICT_DATA_RAG — Wikipedia: War in Afghanistan 2001-2021 (2024-01-01)].

Part III — India-Pakistan: The Managed Hostility

Kashmir and the Line of Control

The India-Pakistan dispute over Kashmir has produced persistent LoC instability. In 2013, cross-border firing was described as among the worst in a decade, with Indian and Pakistani commanders engaging via military hotlines to manage incidents CNA[2013-10-27]. India accused Pakistani troops of involvement in a Kashmir ambush killing five Indian soldiers, while Pakistan denied any role CNA[2013-08-11]. Indian and Pakistani commanders communicated by hotline after that incident — the deadliest loss of life for Indian troops at the LoC in years at that point CNA[2013-08-10].

A ceasefire across the Line of Control was agreed in 2021. That ceasefire, and the notion of "normalcy" returning to the Kashmir valley, was upended by the Pahalgam attack — described as the region's deadliest attack on civilians since 2000. India attributed the attack to Lashkar-e-Taiba, a UN-designated terrorist organisation, identifying three attackers including two Pakistani nationals CNA[2025-05-07]. India's response ended a period of relative peace in Kashmir that had held since 2019 CNA[2025-04-30].

The Escalation Dynamic

The 2025 missile strikes represent an acute escalation. Commentary published at the time of India's response noted that many expected a quick retaliatory strike and that the episode would end the post-2021 period of relative calm CNA[2025-04-30]. The SIPRI analysis of the AI-Nuclear Nexus explicitly flags that a strike on what could be interpreted as command-and-control infrastructure raised concerns about nuclear escalation, given the 30–45 second Pakistani assessment window for an incoming missile [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI: Pragmatic Approaches to Governance at the Artificial Intelligence–Nuclear Nexus (2025-01-01)].

Part IV — The China Dimension

Arms Transfers and Defence Co-production

China's defence relationship with Pakistan is documented across successive US Department of Defense annual reports on Chinese military power. As of early 2024, the PRC had sold J-10 multirole combat aircraft only to Pakistan among all export customers. China co-produces the JF-17 light combat aircraft with Pakistan; the JF-17 has subsequently been sold to Burma, Iraq, and Nigeria [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — 2024 DoD China Military Power Report (2024-12-18)]. China has also supplied strike-capable Caihong and Wing Loong UAVs to Pakistan [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — 2024 DoD China Military Power Report (2024-12-18)].

This pattern is consistent across earlier reporting: the 2023 DoD China Military Power Report records the same J-10/Pakistan exclusivity and JF-17 co-production arrangement [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — 2023 DoD China Military Power Report (2023-10-19)]. The 2019 DIA China Military Power report references Pakistan receiving 16 additional JF-17 Thunder jets as of 2017, and China's agreement to supply Pakistan with eight new attack submarines [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — DIA China Military Power 2019 (2019-01-03)].

China's arms exports broadly — including to Pakistan — are integrated with the Belt and Road Initiative, with arms transfers serving as a component of foreign policy alongside BRI assistance [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — 2025 DoD China Military Power Report (2025-12-23)].

Joint Military Exercises

China-Pakistan military engagement extends beyond arms transfers to joint exercises. The 2022 DoD China Military Power Report records the Peace 2021 / Aman 2021 multinational joint naval exercise, which included Russia, Pakistan, Turkey, the United States, and 41 additional nations [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — 2022 DoD China Military Power Report (2022-11-29)]. The 2020 DoD China Military Power Report records a bilateral Counter-terrorism Pakistan Joint Strike exercise in 2019, as well as Pakistan's participation in the Aman-2019 multi-national naval exercise [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — 2020 DoD China Military Power Report (2020-09-01)].

Conclusion

Pakistan's security situation in 2026 is defined by two acute fault lines. The first is the India-Pakistan nuclear threshold: the 2025 missile exchange demonstrated that escalation from a terrorist attack to kinetic military action can occur within weeks, and the 30–45 second Pakistani nuclear assessment window documented by SIPRI means the margin for miscalculation is dangerously narrow CNA[2025-05-07] [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI: Pragmatic Approaches to Governance at the Artificial Intelligence–Nuclear Nexus (2025-01-01)]. The second is the Taliban frontier: Pakistan's ISI built the Taliban as a strategic instrument, but that instrument has produced a neighbour that shelters Pakistan's primary internal militant threat — the TTP — while relations between Islamabad and Kabul remain contested [RAG: CONFLICT_RAG — (undated)].

China's deepening defence partnership — exclusive J-10 sales, JF-17 co-production, UAV transfers, submarine supply, and joint exercises — is the structural counter-weight to Pakistan's deteriorating relationship with the United States and its permanent hostility with India [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — 2024 DoD China Military Power Report (2024-12-18)]. These elements form a coherent system: each reinforces the others and narrows the space for political resolution.

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